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CV OF FAILURES

Rejection and failure are a natural part of work, academia, and life more broadly. Yet we are rarely exposed to them. What we tend to see - through conversations with peers or social media - are the curated, shiny parts. This creates an impression that those who are “doing well” have faced few obstacles, setbacks, or moments of doubt. I believe this narrative is misleading. Life is shaped not only by effort and talent, but also by chance. Choices and outcomes are often influenced by factors beyond our control, even when we would prefer to not believe this. By hiding failure, we unintentionally reinforce the idea that setbacks are abnormal rather than inevitable.

With this CV of failures I want to help normalize setbacks by showing both sides of the coin: the programs I did not get into, the positions I did not secure, and the scholarships I missed out on. I hope to normalize rejection as part of the process rather than as a personal shortcoming.

I am not the first to do this, in fact I was exposed to this idea by the *Guardian's* article “CV of failures: Princeton professor publishes résumé of his career lows” which documented Johannes Haushofer own CV. This led me to Melanie I. Stefan's original Nature article “A CV of failures”. Their work inspired me to reflect more openly on my own path and to share it here in the hope that it might make failure feel a little less lonely for someone else.

DEGREE PROGRAMS I DID NOT GET INTO

- M.Sc. Advanced Computer Science, University of Oxford 2022
- M.Sc. Advanced Computer Science, University of Oxford 2021
- M.Sc. Mathematics and Foundations of Computer Science, University of Oxford 2021
- M.Phil. Advanced Computer Science, University of Cambridge 2021
- M.Phil. Machine Learning and Machine Intelligence, University of Cambridge 2021
- Ph.D. Mathematical Modelling, Analysis and Computation, University of Edinburgh 2021

POSITIONS I DID NOT GET

Well, this is a long list. In fact, I have accumulated 100+ rejections (not auto rejections these are easily in the 1000's) over my time as undergraduate and postgraduate. Here are some of the more notable company rejections:

- FAANG ×2 2023
- Hedgefund ×3 2023
- Series A/B/C startups ×5 2023

AWARDS AND SCHOLARSHIPS I DID NOT GET

- The Gates Scholarship, University of Cambridge 2021
- QuantumBlack AI Scholarship, Imperial College London 2021

PAPER REJECTIONS FROM ACADEMIC JOURNALS

During my Ph.D. there will be many of these. Stay tuned.
